

Sensory Access at Work

All eight senses, the common access needs at work, and the small changes that make a workplace livable.

Reach for it in the accommodations conversation, when “what do you need?” needs a list rather than an apology.

Your senses are how you meet the world. When a workplace is designed without regard for sensory experience, people are not just uncomfortable — they are harmed. This sheet names common sensory and access needs at work, and the small changes that make a workplace livable.

What This Is

This is a plain reference for sensory and access needs in the workplace.

It covers all eight senses — five external and three internal — plus the non-sensory needs that shape whether work is sustainable. For each one, it lists concrete accommodations that reduce load.

It draws on how Stimpunks describes lived context: Cavendish Space (<https://stimpunks.org/glossary/cavendish-space/>), where people and environments continuously shape each other.

Why This Exists

Most workplaces are built for one narrow way of sensing, moving, and communicating. Anything outside that norm gets labeled a problem.

We name it differently:

- Sensory difference is human variation, not deficit.
- The environment is designed — so it can be redesigned.
- Access is created, not granted.
- We do not accommodate people into harm. We design spaces that stop punishing difference.

Autistic and otherwise neurodivergent people often process sensory input without the usual “fade.” Input stacks faster than it can be cleared. In neuronormative (<https://stimpunks.org/glossary/neuronormativity/>) and ableist (<https://stimpunks.org/glossary/ableism/>) settings, that load is read as fragility

instead of design failure.

The Five External Senses

Sight

- Turn off or dim overhead lighting; allow task lighting and natural light.
- Replace or filter flickering fluorescents.
- Allow sunglasses, hats, brimmed caps, and screen dimming.
- Avoid highly patterned surfaces and glare near workstations.

Sound

- Offer quiet zones and low-stimulation rooms.
- Allow noise-cancelling headphones and ear protection as normal equipment.
- Reduce background noise from HVAC, machinery, and open-plan chatter.
- Keep conversation out of noisy, echoing spaces.

Smell

- Keep shared areas fragrance-aware: no scented cleaners, air fresheners, or aerosols.
- Ask people not to wear strong perfume or cologne.
- Improve ventilation and allow open windows where possible.
- Give a heads-up before painting, cleaning, or other strong-smell work.

Taste

- Respect food preferences without comment or pressure.
- Do not require shared meals or "team lunches" as participation.
- Allow safe foods, familiar brands, and consistent routines.
- Make sure a private, low-stimulation place to eat is available.

Touch

- Ask before any physical contact; do not assume handshakes or casual touch.
- Allow sensory-friendly clothing instead of rigid dress codes.
- Permit fidgets, weighted lap pads, and other stimming (<https://stimpunks.org/glossary/stimming/>) tools.
- Account for temperature: thermal sensitivity is common, so allow layers, personal fans or heaters, and some control over the thermostat.

The Three Internal Senses

Proprioception (body position and movement)

- Allow movement: standing, walking, rocking, pacing, or a sit-stand desk.
- Permit walking meetings and movement breaks.
- Do not read unusual posture as inattention or disrespect.

Vestibular (balance and motion)

- Allow stable, supportive seating and freedom to change position.
- Avoid seating people on high stools or unstable chairs.
- Give warning about anything that moves, spins, or shifts underfoot.

Interoception (internal body signals)

- Build in regular breaks; do not rely on people noticing hunger, thirst, or fatigue on time.
 - Normalize stepping away to eat, drink, use the bathroom, or rest.
 - Ask directly about needs rather than waiting for them to be voiced. Answering may be hard.
- See [interoception \(https://stimpunks.org/glossary/interoception/\)](https://stimpunks.org/glossary/interoception/).

Other Access Needs

Sensory needs rarely travel alone. These non-sensory supports matter just as much.

Communication

- Make written, asynchronous communication normal and respected.
- Allow processing time; a pause is not hesitation.
- Support augmentative and alternative communication (AAC) and text over voice.
- See [Communication and Interaction Access \(https://stimpunks.org/communication-access/\)](https://stimpunks.org/communication-access/).

Attention and focus

- Protect deep-work time and reduce needless interruptions.
- Recognize [monotropic \(https://stimpunks.org/glossary/monotropism/\)](https://stimpunks.org/glossary/monotropism/) attention: single, deep focus that supports [flow \(https://stimpunks.org/glossary/flow/\)](https://stimpunks.org/glossary/flow/) and resents being fragmented.
- Design roles around strengths instead of demanding uniform pace.

Predictability

- Share agendas, questions, and expectations in advance.
- Give realistic notice of changes.
- Provide clear, unambiguous directions and signage.

Meetings

- Send materials ahead; do not require improvised, fast turn-taking.
- Make cameras optional.
- Allow written contributions and follow-up in writing. See [Designing Inclusive Meetings](https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/inclusive-meetings/) (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/inclusive-meetings/>).

Recovery and pacing

- Treat rest, pacing, and access as part of sustainable productivity.
- Watch for sensory load and masking pressure, which compound into burnout.
- See [Preventing Autistic Burnout](https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/prevent-autistic-burnout/) (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/prevent-autistic-burnout/>).

How to Use This

- Bring it to a manager, HR, or an access conversation as a starting point.
- Pick the entries that fit you; you do not need every item.
- Pair it with the [Sensory Checklist Gallery](https://stimpunks.org/access/sensory-checklist-gallery/) (<https://stimpunks.org/access/sensory-checklist-gallery/>) and [Create a Neurodiversity Inclusive Environment](https://stimpunks.org/design/create-a-neurodiversity-inclusive-environment/) (<https://stimpunks.org/design/create-a-neurodiversity-inclusive-environment/>) to audit a specific space.
- Use [Designing Sensory-Safe Spaces](https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/sensory-safe-spaces/) (<https://stimpunks.org/patterns/recipes/sensory-safe-spaces/>) and [The Inclusive Power of the Dimmer Switch](https://stimpunks.org/2024/06/24/the-inclusive-power-of-the-dimmer-switch/) (<https://stimpunks.org/2024/06/24/the-inclusive-power-of-the-dimmer-switch/>) for practical, low-cost changes.
- Write a personal [collaboration manual](https://stimpunks.org/2026/05/27/write-a-neurodivergent-collaboration-manual/) (<https://stimpunks.org/2026/05/27/write-a-neurodivergent-collaboration-manual/>) to say how you work best.

What This Is Not

- Not a diagnosis or a medical form.
- Not a fixed checklist every person must match.
- Not a claim that difference is deficit.
- Not a demand to "just try harder" once the environment is named.

Who This Is For

- Neurodivergent and Disabled workers naming what they need.
- Managers, HR, and teammates who want to reduce pointless friction.
- Anyone designing or adjusting a shared workspace.

Quick Summary

Your nervous system is real, and the environment is designed. Small, low-cost changes across the eight senses — and across communication, focus, predictability, and recovery — turn a workplace from injurious to livable. This is access as infrastructure, not an afterthought. See [Neurodivergent Workplaces](https://stimpunks.org/environments/neurodivergent-workplaces/) and [Neuroception and Sensory Load](https://stimpunks.org/access/sensory-experience/).

Signatories

The following individuals, organizations, and communities endorse this [Why Sheet](https://stimpunks.org/why/). Want to join them? [Add your signature.](https://stimpunks.org/fieldguide/operations/forms/sign-why-sheet/)

- [Stimpunks Foundation](https://stimpunks.org/)

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Where this sheet comes from. It is written and revised as Markdown in the open: [Sensory Access at Work.md](#). That file is the source this page and its PDF are both generated from, so the three cannot say different things.

This sheet is also published as a page on stimpunks.org.

There is a [one-sheet broadside](#) of this argument — the version you pin up.